



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

HOMES in the Capistrano Beach community of Dana Point have been severely damaged by recent storms.

FEDS TO EXAMINE POOR STATE OF L.A. JAIL

Justice Department to look at whether county is providing humane conditions for inmates.

By SALVADOR HERNANDEZ AND JAMES QUEALLY

The U.S. Justice Department has launched an investigation into Los Angeles County's Men's Central Jail after years of concerns about poor conditions and inmate deaths.

The government will look into whether the county has provided "humane" conditions to individuals housed there, and notified Sheriff Robert Luna of the federal inquiry in a letter Wednesday, according to a Justice Department news release.

"Whether a person is held in a county jail, awaiting trial, or after conviction, the environmental conditions in that jail need to meet constitutional standards," Assistant Atty. Gen. Harmeet K. Dhillon said in a statement.

It marks the latest in a string of both federal and state investigations in the last few decades of the Sheriff's Department and problems in the jails. Despite the investigations and promises of reforms, critics say underlying problems persist.

The most sensational of the federal inquiries involved allegations of deputy mistreatment of inmates. Prosecutors said then-Sheriff [See Jail, A5]

Hollywood fears an AI future. China lives in it

By Ling Wei and Liza Lin

Chen Yilong has racked up plenty of film and TV credits in his two decades as an actor, but with work getting scarcer he signed a contract in August to license the image of his face to a Chinese production studio.

Chen's role will be to sit in front of a video camera and make facial expressions at the prompt of a director. A neutral stare. An angry glare. A look of surprise. Using artificial intelligence, the studio will use images of Chen's face to generate an avatar, also known as a "digital human," to star in an AI-generated movie.

"If you can't beat it, join it," said Chen, 38, who works in Beijing.

The Chinese film and video industry is being transformed by AI-driven storytelling, fueled by rapid advances in video generation software, and at ground zero are the so-called micro dramas that play out on millions of smartphones.

Typically just a minute or two in length, the videos are devoured by Chi-

nese audiences at breakfast, on their morning commutes, during their lunch breaks and on their free time after work — and almost any time in between.

More of a snack than a meal, micro dramas are fleeting and don't demand the same top-notch acting and high quality resolution as movies, making them an ideal vehicle for AI-generated content. And the cost of producing them has been cut drastically through the use of AI software developed by Chinese technology juggernauts including Kuaishou Technology and TikTok's global owner, ByteDance.

The number of Chinese-made micro dramas surged in the first three months of this year to 128,000, according to the China Netcasting Services Assn. More than 95% of them were made with AI, the association said.

Similar tools are being tested in the U.S., and the AI trends upending China's entertainment [See China, A11]

Burying hatchet to save trees

Some environmentalists join loggers in backing forestry bill

By NOAH HAGGERTY

A sweeping bipartisan bill that seeks to prevent catastrophic wildfires and restore fire-ravaged forests has revealed a schism in the nation's environmental movement as some conservation advocates find themselves allied with a longtime foe: loggers.

The Fix Our Forests Act, which Congress is close to passing, aims to speed up forest management projects on public and tribal lands by reducing regulatory and legal hurdles.

The proposed legislation comes at a time of increasingly devastating wildfires and has garnered wide sup-

port among Republicans and the timber industry.

However, the traditional Democratic coalition of environmental groups is split over the role humanity has to play in forest management. Some argue ecosystems are best protected when humans leave them alone — a view that dominated during the timber wars of the '80s and '90s. Others argue that humans have a responsibility to intervene — an increasingly popular idea as climate change threatens ecosystems around the world.

Among the major environmental groups that oppose the legislation are the Sierra Club and Center for Biological Diversity. They

worry that limiting environmental review and litigation will allow timber companies to heavily log these areas instead of gently thinning them. Meanwhile, some Southern California groups worry the bill would allow well-meaning land managers to approve misguided projects that ultimately harm local shrublands, which have a very different relationship with fire than the bill's namesake, forests.

"It's really handing the keys to the Trump administration to be able to push forward a lot of their timber agenda," said Anna Medema, deputy legislative director for forests and public lands at the Sierra Club. [See Wildfires, A7]

Damaging waves offer warning for El Niño winter

High surf slams coast from Malibu to San Diego. Long Beach homes are hit hard.

By GRACE TOOHEY

To begin to understand how a "super" El Niño winter could punish the Southern California coast, the historic wooden boardwalk on the Long Beach peninsula may just offer a glimpse at what's to come.

Days of intense waves fueled by Hurricane Marie far away in the Pacific left several sections of the boardwalk destroyed after massive swells swallowed protective sand berms and slammed through the seawall.

That force also left several oceanfront homes damaged, some flooded, with at least 24 homes put under evacuation orders until Wednesday morning, as officials assessed the extent of structural damage from the storm, according to the Long Beach Fire Department.

"The whole beach is gone," said Carmen Vaudry, 58, describing how the sand used to sit just below the boardwalk in front of her home but now appears to have dropped several feet.

But Long Beach wasn't the only victim of the ocean's effortless wrath over the weekend. High surf pounded the region's increasingly fragile coastline from Malibu to San Diego, and experts say it could be only a taste of what is ahead as the El Niño forecast continues to strengthen.

"Unfortunately, this is just a preview," University of California climate scientist Daniel Swain said Tuesday during a discussion of the storm. "The coastal flooding later this year ... it will get worse this fall and especially this winter."

In Dana Point, relentless waves damaged several beachfront homes, destroying decks and tearing through walls. City officials on Tuesday "red-tagged" seven of those homes in the Capistrano Bay District community, deeming them unsafe for residents, and two others were "yellow-tagged," signifying some safety concerns, according to Dana Point officials. [See El Niño, A7]

'Perfect' L.A. weather goes wild

Southern California, known for a dry heat, is experiencing extreme humidity. **CALIFORNIA, B1**



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

POWERED by innovators in space, finance, toys and sports, El Segundo is shedding its former insularity.

El Segundo's deep into its second act

South Bay refinery town has reinvented itself as a 'bougie' high-tech nucleus.

By ROGER VINCENT

Hemmed in by a refinery, LAX and miles of factories and warehouses, El Segundo was once a working-class neighborhood better known for its aroma than its lifestyle.

Today, powered by SpaceX and other high-tech, high-growth companies, it has evolved into an upscale enclave perfectly positioned for some of the region's hottest businesses.

The South Bay city is building a new narrative, using the warehouses, offices, industrial lots and homes that were part of its deep history in aerospace, oil and defense and catching the next waves of innovation in space, finance, sports and even toys.

SpaceX started in El Segundo and has since spawned more than 100 startups, many in the area. Space X is now based in Texas but it retains significant operations in Hawthorne. The company's alumni sometimes call each other "Gundo bros," after their old stomping ground.

A growing ecosystem of toy designers and manufacturers has emerged around Mattel, which has its headquarters in El Segundo. Meanwhile, the region has emerged as a mecca for pro sports, with top basketball and hockey teams building elaborate practice facilities there.

Krystal Robbins, a 21-year resident of El Segundo, said the city has come a long way from the days when some called it Smell Segundo. Air quality has improved, as has the town's quality of life.

Her family has enjoyed what feels like small-town life while rubbing elbows [See El Segundo, A10]

COLUMN ONE

A bumpy road to the American dream

At 4 o'clock on a Thursday morning, Salomon Olea grabbed a packed lunch of a ham-and-cheese torta and a white peach, kissed his wife goodbye and left the home in Escondido he's owned for nearly 30 years.

He drove five minutes to a small apartment complex to pick up his son, Angel, whose own three children were still asleep. The men then drove another half hour in silence, the head beams of their car the only lights on otherwise deserted streets.

The Olea men both drive commercial trash trucks for a private waste company. They spend 12 hours a day navigating the same route through the northern suburbs of San Diego, where they unload recycling and

Dad built a life on a trash hauler's pay; son finds it's just not enough

By Audrey McGlinchy
REPORTING FROM ESCONDIDO, CALIF.



SANDY HUFFAKER For The Times

SALOMON and Angel Olea, father and son, have similar jobs but starkly different financial realities.

trash bins from schools, restaurants, convenience stores and, in one case, a church.

It's exhausting work, but for the older generation of truck drivers, which includes Salomon, 55, it has meant a stable life. They have been able to buy homes and raise families in safe neighborhoods in Southern California — all on a trashman's paycheck.

For a time, these kinds of working-class jobs, or jobs that demand manual labor, were a route to the American dream of homeownership.

Between 1980 and 1990, men without college degrees saw their incomes rise relative to the average U.S. worker. Around the same decade, more than two-thirds of construction work-

[See Sanitation, A6]

State's water plan is under attack

Trump administration opposes Sacramento-San Joaquin River Delta regulations. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Facing familiar foe Down Under

Rams open their season and begin Super Bowl pursuit against 49ers in Australia. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather

Hot and humid. L.A. Basin: 96/73. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

Legal cloud over Lucas Museum

As museum nears grand opening, lawsuits shed fresh light on land deal. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



7 85944 00200 5